

Human Services Directory Examples — Overview

Purpose: Reference deck comparing existing service finders and directory platforms from around the world.

Audience: Porirua Locality stakeholders, funders, and project team.

Use: Read as a document, or one section = one slide.

Slide 1 — Why look at other directories?

Before building the Porirua Services Directory, it helps to see what already works elsewhere.

Good directories share common traits:

- **Plain language** — “I need food”, not bureaucratic category codes
- **Location-first** — show what is near the person
- **Trust** — accurate phone numbers, reviewed listings
- **Mobile-friendly** — most people search on a phone
- **Two audiences** — public help-seekers and referral workers (optional admin layer)

This deck summarises **six examples** worth studying — live directories, community maps, and one ready-made toolkit.

Slide 2 — Ask Izzy (Australia)

What it is: Free, anonymous mobile website connecting people across Australia with health and welfare services.

Website: askizzy.org.au

About: about.askizzy.org.au

Coverage	National — ~450,000 services
Entry point	“What do you need help with?” categories (Food, Housing, Money help, etc.)
Data	Powered by Infoxchange Service Directory — dedicated team of 15+ database updaters
Special feature	Zero-data access on some mobile networks
Built with	Next.js (open source on GitHub)

What works well

- Categories written for people in crisis, not for administrators
- Separate site for service providers with resources and downloads
- Co-designed with people who have experienced homelessness

Limitation for Porirua

- National scale and budget — not realistic to replicate the full data operation locally

Relevance to Porirua: Best UX reference for categories + mobile layout.

Slide 3 — 211 (United States & Canada)

What it is: Free, confidential helpline and web directory connecting people to local community services.

Websites: 211.org (US) · 211.ca (Canada)

Coverage	~1.7 million local programs (US); nationwide in Canada
Entry point	Dial 2-1-1, chat, text, or web — trained navigators available
Data	Standardised national dataset + local 211 centres
Volume	19+ million referrals per year (US, 2025)

What works well

- **Human + digital** — people can talk to someone, not just search a website
- Handles **compound needs** (housing + food + utilities in one conversation)
- Available in 180+ languages (US)
- Strong partner network (United Way, government, nonprofits)

Limitation for Porirua

- Requires call centre infrastructure and sustained funding

Relevance to Porirua: Gold standard for referral quality; shows why plain categories and local filtering matter.

Slide 4 — Family Services Directory (New Zealand)

What it is: Government-hosted online database of social service providers across Aotearoa.

Website: familyservices.govt.nz/directory

Open data: data.govt.nz — [Family Services Directory](#)

Coverage	National — several thousand organisations
Entry point	Keyword search + category + region filter
Data	Maintained by Ministry of Social Development
Special feature	Zero-data mobile access; regional Excel downloads; machine-readable API

What works well

- Official, trusted source for NZ social services
- Open data enables other apps (including Porirua’s planned weekly sync)
- Free for public and embeddable in community tools

Limitation for Porirua

- Not Porirua-specific — requires filtering and local curation
- Generic categories — less community kaupapa than a local map

Relevance to Porirua: Primary **data source** for the planned directory (not the UX model).

Slide 5 — Sorted Local Help (United Kingdom)

What it is: Postcode-based router to local council hardship funds, food banks, warm hubs, and legal aid.

Website: sorteduk.uk/local-help

Coverage	UK-wide — 317 councils, 2,800+ food banks
Entry point	Enter postcode → unlock everything local
Data	Aggregates council sites, Trussell Trust, Turn2us, Law Centres Network

What works well

- One simple action (postcode) unlocks many local schemes
- Honest about variation between councils
- Sources cited and last-verified dates shown

Limitation for Porirua

- UK-specific institutions (councils, postcodes)

Relevance to Porirua: Inspiration for “one lookup, many local results” — adapted as suburb/search for Porirua.

Slide 6 — Kore Hiakai — Community Food Map (New Zealand)

What it is: National map of community food organisations — food banks, social supermarkets, community meals, free stores.

Website: zerohunger.org.nz/find-a-community-food-organisation

Coverage	NZ community food providers
Entry point	Interactive map + organisation type filters
Data	Community-led; organisations can request to be added via survey
Tone	Explains dignity-focused models (social supermarkets vs traditional food banks)

What works well

- **Community-owned** narrative — not a government catalogue
- Clear language about different food support models
- Transparent that the map is “comprehensive, not exhaustive”

Limitation for Porirua

- Food-only — not a general social services directory

Relevance to Porirua: Local trust model; Te Umu ki Rangituhi and Pātaka Kai align with this ecosystem. Complements FSD rather than replacing it.

Slide 7 — Homeless England (United Kingdom)

What it is: Comprehensive database of homelessness services in England.

Website: homeless.org.uk/homeless-england

Coverage	~1,500 projects nationally
Entry point	Search + detailed service-type filters
Operator	Homeless Link (sector body)
Audience	People experiencing homelessness + sector workers

What works well

- Deep filtering (hostels, outreach, day centres, Housing First, etc.)
- Sector-maintained — practitioners trust the listings
- Promotes joint working across organisations

Limitation for Porirua

- Single domain (homelessness) — narrow but deep

Relevance to Porirua: Example of a **specialist directory done well** — useful if Porirua later adds housing-focused views.

Slide 8 — ORServices (Open source platform)

What it is: Free, open-source, smartphone-friendly directory application for health, human, and social services. Built for communities that want their **own** directory without expensive proprietary 211 software.

Website: sarapis.org/human-services/orservices

Code: github.com/sarapis/orservices

Type	Platform (admin + public site in one) — not a live national directory
Data	Import and export spreadsheet-friendly lists
Cost	Free software — you pay for hosting and setup

Features

- Public geo-aware search and filtering
- **Built-in admin** — manage organisations, services, locations, contacts
- Import from spreadsheets and export lists (portable data)
- Customisable home page, colours, logos
- Role-based users (editors per organisation)
- PDF/CSV download of filtered lists
- Google Translate integration

What works well

- **All-in-one** — directory + admin + data standard in a single deployable package

- Designed as affordable alternative to US 211 proprietary systems
- Data can be exported if you change systems later
- Self-hostable — you control hosting and longevity

Limitations

- Requires PHP/MySQL server and technical setup (not static hosting)
- Smaller community (~30 GitHub stars) — less mainstream than WordPress
- Would still need custom work for FSD sync and Porirua branding
- Laravel/PHP hosting and security updates are ongoing responsibility

Relevance to Porirua

Consider	Detail
Alternative to	Building custom admin (Directus) + separate public app
Pros	Purpose-built for exactly this use case; all-in-one package
Cons	Heavier ops than Postgres + Directus + static frontend; 100h budget tight for customising Laravel app
Best fit when	Team wants one deployed product and has technical hosting support

Demo / docs: See README on [GitHub — sarapis/orservices](https://github.com/sarapis/orservices) for installation requirements (PHP 8.1+, MySQL, Composer).

Slide 9 — Side-by-side comparison

Example	Type	Coverage	Public search?	Admin built-in?	Best lesson for Porirua
Ask Izzy	Live directory	Australia	Yes	Separate provider site	Category UX, mobile-first
211	Helpline + directory	US/Canada	Yes	Professional navigators	Compound needs, human backup
Family Services Directory	Live directory	NZ national	Yes	Govt back-end	Our FSD data source
Sorted UK	Local router	UK	Yes	None public	Postcode/suburb → local help
Kore Hiakai	Community map	NZ food	Yes	Survey to add orgs	Local trust, dignity language
Homeless England	Specialist directory	England	Yes	Sector-maintained	Deep filters for one domain

ORServices	Open platform	Deploy anywhere	Yes (when hosted)	Yes — full CMS	All-in-one OSS alternative
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Slide 10 — Three architectural paths

Path A — Reference UX only (current plan)

FSD + Connections Map → Postgres → Directus admin → static public site

Learn from: Ask Izzy (UX), FSD (data), Kore Hiakai (local layer)

Path B — ORServices as the platform

Import government and local data into ORServices → public site + admin included

Learn from: ORServices

Trade-off: PHP/Laravel hosting; customise imports for NZ sources

Path C — Hybrid

ORServices or custom backend for data/admin; custom Porirua-branded frontend

Trade-off: More integration work; most flexible UX

Porirua requirements doc (v1) follows **Path A** for budget, longevity, and team familiarity — but **ORServices remains a credible Path B** if the team prefers a single open-source product over Directus + custom frontend.

Slide 11 — What Porirua is taking from each

From	Porirua adopts
Ask Izzy	Plain-language categories, “find help now and nearby”
211	Crisis numbers visible; compound needs across categories
Family Services Directory	Weekly automated national data sync
Kore Hiakai / Connections Map	Local organisations, kaupapa, community trust
ORServices	Optional all-in-one toolkit (public site + editing tools together)
Sorted UK	Simple local entry (suburb/search → results)

Not copying: National scale, call centres, zero-data telco deals, or 15-person data teams.

Slide 12 — Further reading

Resource	URL
Ask Izzy	https://www.askizzy.org.au/
Ask Izzy (open source)	https://github.com/ask-izzy/ask-izzy
211 United States	https://www.211.org/

211 Canada	https://211.ca/
NZ Family Services Directory	https://www.familyservices.govt.nz/directory/
FSD open data	https://catalogue.data.govt.nz/dataset/family-services-directory
Sorted Local Help	https://sorteduk.uk/local-help
Kore Hiakai food map	https://www.zerohunger.org.nz/find-a-community-food-organisation
Homeless England	https://homeless.org.uk/homeless-england/
ORServices	https://github.com/sarapis/orservices
ORServices (Sarapis)	https://sarapis.org/human-services/orservices/
Porirua Community Connections Map	https://www.porirualocality.co.nz/poriruacommunityconnectionsmap
Porirua requirements doc	docs/porirua-services-directory-requirements.md (this repo)

Slide 13 — Summary

- **Live directories** (Ask Izzy, 211, FSD) show what good **public UX** and **data maintenance** look like at scale.
- **Community maps** (Kore Hiakai, Connections Map) show how **local trust** beats generic listings.
- **ORServices** is a **free ready-made toolkit** — public directory website and editing tools in one package — worth comparing to building our own.
- Porirua's directory combines the best of these: **Ask Izzy-style UX**, **FSD data**, and **local Connections Map**, on a **stable, exportable** technical base.